

Hypothesis and Imagination Series ①

6. Conclusion to Part I: A Strategy of Correlative Thinking

Human Survival Strategy through Correlative Thinking and Hwajaeng in the AI Era · Choi Won-hyeok

6. Conclusion to Part I: A Strategy of Correlative Thinking

On the vast silk tapestry of history, the AI revolution is like a new thread—glimmering with hope while also carrying the threat of unraveling existing patterns. To weave this thread in harmony, humanity must remember the skill of the master weaver: one who sees the entire design, understands the color and role of each thread, and possesses the patience and creativity to make adjustments when the pattern goes awry. In other words, we must take correlative thinking—that is, relational and holistic thinking—as our fundamental strategy.

6.1. The Organic Consilience of the Four Modes of Thinking

The four modes of correlative thinking are not tools used separately but an engine that turns together. When stereoscopic thinking lets us see reality from multiple angles, cyclical thinking lets us read the flow of time within those multiple angles, empathy lets us connect the hearts of the people within that flow, and convergence combines all of this into new value. If any one is missing, the rest cannot function fully either. Without seeing relationships stereoscopically, the depth of empathy becomes shallow; without knowing the rhythm of the cycle, one misses the timing of convergence.

Consider the analogy of a school project. Examining the topic from many perspectives when first choosing it is stereoscopic thinking; the process of gathering material, discarding it, and reorganizing it again is cyclical thinking; coordinating and encouraging the opinions of group members is empathy; and turning each person's output into one completed presentation is convergence. In the AI era, training in these four is a way of building individual competitiveness, but beyond that, it is also a way of cultivating a civilization's capacity to transform conflict into Hwajaeng.

The four-stage methodology presented in this text—stereoscopic thinking (Ipche, Mimesis), cyclical thinking (Sunhwan, Mythos), empathy (Gonggam, Logos), and convergence (Yunghap, Theos)—constitutes, on the basis of correlative thinking, a coherent strategy that contributes to human adaptation and flourishing in the AI era. Each stage is interconnected and generates synergy: "stereoscopic" understanding influences the way we recognize "cyclical" patterns, and "empathy" becomes an essential condition for meaningful "convergence." This multidimensional approach lays a foundation on which humans can complement AI's analytical capabilities, respond flexibly amid unpredictable change, and guide technology to align with human-centered values. Daoist mimesis, through the principle of complementarity, offers the harmonious coexistence of AI and humanity; Buddhist mythos, through the thought of Dependent Origination and Emptiness, offers the wisdom of relational becoming; Confucian logos, grounded in Ren (benevolence), offers a new

ethics of relationship; and convergence, as the Fourth Thought, embraces all of these and points the way to the creation of new value.

6.2. Toward a New Renaissance

In an AI-driven world, human correlative capacities such as empathy, holistic understanding, ethical judgment, meaning-making, and creative synthesis are distinctively human strengths whose value only rises as AI handles routine analytical tasks. The AI era paradoxically demands of us that we "cherish what makes humans human—namely, holistic intelligence—and organize society accordingly." This is a path that opens a new horizon in the AI era not through competition with machines but through the deepening and manifestation of human uniqueness. AI is a powerful tool, but it cannot be an end in itself. Humans must use AI as a means to realize the ultimate purposes of human dignity, happiness, and the prosperity of the community. This means guarding against technological absolutism, restoring human-centered values, and aspiring to a new Renaissance that humans and AI will create together.

6.3. Approaches to Education and Social Practice

Correlative thinking is not a difficult and complex Eastern philosophy but a concrete habit of thought that can be practiced in real life. In the educational setting, the best way to cultivate correlative thinking is training that asks "why" and "how" together. The starting point of correlative thinking is the habit of considering, rather than simply finding the correct answer, why something is a problem, how it looks from other perspectives, and whom the solution affects and in what way.

At the level of social practice, creating spaces for "slow dialogue" is important. The AI era demands fast information and immediate responses, but correlative thinking and Hwajaeng grow out of "slow dialogue" that takes ample time to understand one another. Only when institutional spaces for such "slow dialogue"—community discussion groups, philosophy classes in schools, corporate ethics discussion sessions, and government public-deliberation processes—remain alive even in the AI era does the practice of Hwajaeng become possible.

AI companies and platforms can also take part in the practice of correlative thinking. Including users of diverse cultures, ages, and income levels when designing AI systems, regularly reviewing and disclosing algorithmic bias, and providing content that educates users to use AI critically—all of these are corporate-level practices of correlative thinking. Companies that invest in designing their relationships with people as much as in the speed of technological development will become the true leading enterprises of the AI era.

The manifestation of these human attributes does not come about on its own. It requires conscious effort through education, policy-making, cultural development, and personal practice. Humans must move beyond being mere "problem solvers" to perform the role of "meaning solvers" amid a complex world and technology. This will be the core driving force that enables humans to develop without losing their agency in the AI era, harmonizing technology with human values.

Educational innovation: We must move away from memorization-centered education toward education that cultivates correlative thinking capacities such as critical thinking, creative problem-solving ability, empathy, and collaboration skills.

Redesigning social systems: We must build inclusive social systems so that the benefits of technological development are shared across society as a whole and so that no marginalization arises from technology. A process of establishing AI ethical standards and reaching social consensus on the development and use of AI technology is necessary.

Cultural reflection and practice: Through ceaseless self-reflection and learning, individuals must adapt to a changing era, and within their communities they must stand in solidarity with others and pursue a meaningful life. Effort is needed to apply correlative thinking to daily life and work.

The integration of Eastern wisdom and Western rationality, and of human ability and AI tools, foretells the emergence of a new kind of human—one technically proficient yet possessed of deep wisdom—namely the "wise cyborg" or "hybrid thinker." The Hallyu (Korean Wave) phenomenon can be seen as one example of such a successful strategy of synthesis, and "Hallyu as a new-human strategy of stereoscopic thinking, cyclical thinking, and empathy" implies the possibilities that cultural convergence presents.

Ultimately, what distinguishes and guides us in the AI-driven hyperconnected world is the uniquely human capacity for holistic, interconnected reasoning, reinforced by bodily presence and intuition. Just as Yin and Yang taught that manifest opposites can form a larger whole, human intuition and artificial intelligence too, if approached wisely, can form a partnership greater than the sum of its parts. Just as the Five Phases remind us that balance and cyclical renewal are the key to longevity, we must maintain a balance between technological advancement and ethical, emotional, and cultural renewal. The stories and contingencies of life remind us that we are not the objects of algorithms but the subjects of our own destiny. If we remember that we are the ultimate connectors, we need not fear the hyperconnected future.

"The silk of civilization will surely take on new patterns, yet it will still be woven by human hands, according to wisdom born of long-standing hypothesis and imagination—a true triumph of hypothesis and imagination that the two have

created together." By thinking within the whole and within relationships, feeling deeply, creating boldly, and acting according to conscience, humans will be able not merely to survive in the AI era but to blossom within it.

II. Applications: Hwajaeng Theory and the Symbiotic Economy